

Title

Understanding Participant Engagement in Cardiac Rehabilitation: Effects of Structured Behaviour Change Support on Exercise Maintenance

Abstract

Qualitative interviews and focus groups with cardiac rehabilitation participants revealed multiple dimensions influencing sustained physical activity. Both standard and enhanced intervention groups identified professional oversight, peer interaction, and structured programming as important contributors to exercise participation. The behaviour change coaching arm reported additional facilitators including individualised goal negotiation, external accountability mechanisms, and self-tracking approaches that heightened awareness of activity patterns. Qualitative thematic analysis identified increased confidence and sense of achievement as key mechanisms linking coaching strategies to sustained engagement. Conversely, perceived inadequacy in exercise capacity represented a barrier to independent practice following rehabilitation conclusion. Attendance rates and diary data indicated comparable engagement during formal sessions across both arms. Participant interviews revealed that while coaching provided additional motivational support, the fundamental value of professional guidance and social reinforcement inherent to standard rehabilitation was perceived as equally central. Quantitative outcome measures showed improvements in cardiovascular parameters in both groups, though sustained long-term behaviour change rates remain uncertain beyond the structured rehabilitation period.